

On dry land

Water is hard to find in the desert, but when the rains come, the plants are ready. They can take in lots of water in a short time, and store water for a long time. Plants that store water in their leaves or stems are called succulents.

The word "cactus" comes from the Greek kaktos, which means "prickly plant".

WATER STORAGE

Many cactus stems look like they are creased. These deep ridges show clearly when the plant is dry. When the rains come, the ridges expand so the cactus has room to take in lots of water. Rather than having leaves, a cactus has spines growing from its stem. They protect the fat, juicy plant from being eaten by animals that are looking for a quick drink.

